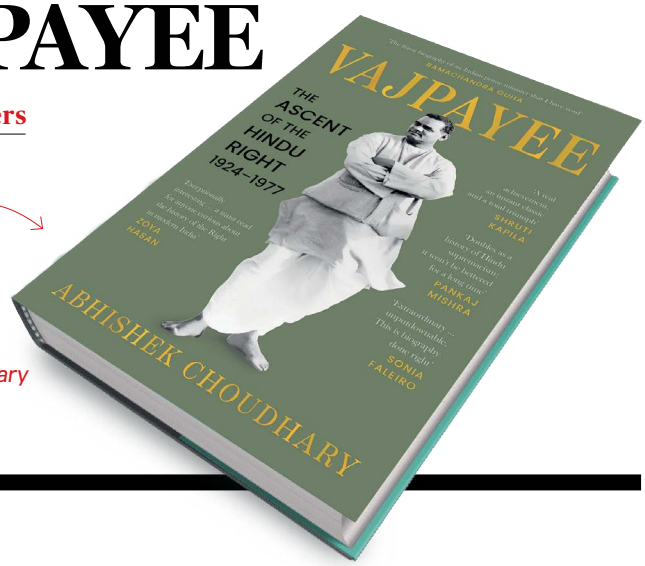
BOOKS

KNOWING VAJPAYEE

By Gilles Verniers



VAJPAYEE: The Ascent of the Hindu Right 1924-1977
By Abhishek Choudhary
PICADOR INDIA
₹899; 432 pages

How is it that some political figures loom large in our collective memory and yet remain enigmatic, if not little-known? Atal Bihari Vajpayee is certainly one such figure, one of India's most consequential politicians, not just for the party he steered for more than five decades, but also for the country he played a part in shaping as a political activist, a lifelong RSS member, a party leader, a parliamentarian, and a prime minister. And yet, his life has been reduced to stereotypical notions and snippets: Vajpayee the moderate, the poet-orator, the non-vegetarian, whisky-drinking *pracharak*, or the right man in the wrong party. Some of these notions, it turns out, are, at best, mild distortions of the truth. Others are misrepresentations of a complex man who, for all his unconventionalities, dedicated his life to the Sangh Parivar's political project of making India Hindu with great constancy and consistency.

To separate the wheat from the chaff of such representations, we turn to biographers who undertake the painstaking work of sifting through the tiniest details of a person's life, rely on primary sources to sort fact from fiction, and critically assess popular views, while steering clear of unfounded speculations. On all these counts, Abhishek Choudhary's spectacular biography of Atal Bihari Vajpayee is a resounding success.

The first volume spans the early years of Vajpayee's life and political engagement till the end of the Emergency. In three sections, Choudhary portrays the familial and social environment in which Vajpayee's worldview was formed, his rise as a party-builder and parliamentarian, and his role first as Nehru's and then Indira Gandhi's opponent.

Choudhary's account of Vajpayee's first political steps describes a universe where the ideological boundaries dividing Congress and the Hindu right's rank and file are porous, if not fluid. Political scientists had observed this in the 1960s, but it's worth recalling at a time when the rigidity of ideological differentiation between parties tends to be exaggerated.

Choudhary retraces Vajpayee's intellectual and political trajectory through his publications, parliamentary speeches, and accounts of both foreign and domestic travels. What emerges is the portrait of a man rigorously aligned with the Sangh's core ideology, yet capable of introspection and autonomous thinking. Choudhary sheds new light on the influence Vajpayee's foreign trips had in broadening his political views.

Choudhary's meticulous research enables him to rectify a few myths, such as the fabrication that Vajpayee played a role in the creation of the Jan Sangh, a party in which he had no formal position before the death of its first president, S.P. Mookerjee; or that he compared Indira Gandhi to Durga in Parliament after victory in the Bangladesh Liberation War. In passing, Choudhary reveals that Vajpayee inflated his curriculum vitae when he fought his first election in Lucknow in 1955. More importantly, the book rightly focuses on Vajpayee's critical role as an organisation-builder, an aspect that has been overshadowed by his more public achievements. The book also reminds us that Vajpayee's career was initially marked more by defeat than victory, and that it took years of determination to steer his party and himself towards a path of political success.

This well-researched and crisply-written biography comes at a time when political figures of the past are being transformed into icons adapted to present-day politics. This usually involves hollowing out their character and reducing long, complicated existences to a few stereotypical representations that often distort the truth. Gandhi's image and ideas get reduced to a pair of spectacles and public hygiene. Ambedkar becomes a figure to appeal to Dalits but is emptied of his critique of caste and Hinduism. Similarly, Vajpayee has been reduced to a heroic figure stripped of its complexity and contradictions.

Like all good biographers, Choudhary informs us not just about an individual but about the world they've inhabited and how they've contributed to shaping it. In this regard, this exemplary biography may become the definitive work on Vajpayee, placed in a different league from other recent hagiographic or more speculative accounts of his life. The second volume is eagerly awaited. ■

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